
From the Alpine woods to Transylvania: Emigration of Italian forestry workers to Austria-Hungary (1880s-1914)

Vincenzo Colaprice*¹, Csongor Jánosi*¹, and Claudio Lorenzini*¹

¹Università degli studi di Torino = University of Turin (UNITO) – Italy

Abstract

The migration of skilled Italian workers to Eastern Europe, from both the Kingdom of Italy and the Italian provinces of the Habsburg Monarchy, has a long history, although the mid-19th century marked a turning point in professional specialization and mobility patterns. Historiography has focused mainly on construction workers active in Transylvania where architects and stonemasons became increasingly predominant from the 1850s onward. Their movement were initially described as periodic migration, shaped by compact groups of workers and contractually defined working hours.

Much less attention has been paid to another sector undergoing rapid expansion in the same decades: forestry. The growth of this industry was tied to the expansion of the ‘timber frontier’ towards Central and Eastern Europe, sustained by the development of railway lines.

A significant share of forest workers in Transylvania, particularly those skilled in logging and floating, came from north-eastern Italy. Their employment was particularly significant in areas where major forestry entrepreneurs operated, such as Count Ármin Mikes in Gelence and Zabola (Háromszék County) and the Feltrinelli brothers in Nagytalmács (Sibiu County).

The core research question is: how did specialised forestry labour mobility connect Alpine communities, employers, and industrial forest sites across the Austro-Hungarian space, and what kinds of social, family, and spatial networks sustained this circulation? A related question concerns whether these movements should be understood primarily as temporary male labour migration or, in some cases, as broader family relocation processes. The case of Pontebba is particularly significant, as a border community located between the Kingdom of Italy and the Habsburg Monarchy until 1915, and as a place from which many individuals involved in forestry work departed.

Methodologically, the paper combines demographic sources, historical network analysis, and GIS-based spatial visualisation. The main source base consists of the civil registers of Pontebba for the period 1871–1915, especially death registers and records of births occurring outside the municipality. Death registers make it possible to identify workers who died beyond the municipal and national borders, including causes and places of death; birth records, by contrast, allow us to detect cases in which entire family groups moved to migration destinations. These data are systematically cross-checked with ecclesiastical and civil registration records from the principal forestry destinations in Transylvania, including Gelence, Nagytalmács, Kistalmács, and Riuszád. The combined source base makes it possible to reconstruct

*Speaker

individual migration trajectories, family networks, employers, places of origin, destinations, and patterns of settlement across the Austro-Hungarian space.

Preliminary results suggest that the migration of Italian forestry workers was not organised around isolated destinations but rather through an interconnected network of forestry and industrial settlements. Pontebba emerges as a key hub linking multiple Transylvanian timber enterprises. The network reveals particularly strong connections with Gelence, Nagytalmács, Nădrag, Petroșani, and Oțelu Roșu, while the demographic evidence also points to cases of family relocation and longer-term settlement rather than exclusively temporary male labour migration.

By integrating fragmentary demographic evidence with spatial and network methods, the paper shows how historical network research can illuminate labour circulation across imperial borderlands and reveal the social infrastructure behind the expansion of the nineteenth-century timber economy.

References

- Bemmann, Martin. 2024. "Wood-Based Businesses and the Economic Development of Europe in the Nineteenth and Twentieth Centuries: An Introduction." *Jahrbuch für Wirtschaftsgeschichte* 65 (2): 279–305. <https://doi.org/10.1515/jbwg-2024-0015>.
- Boca Stângaciu, Anca. 2005. "Forestiera Feltrinelli Sibiu, importantă societate cu participare italiană din industria forestieră românească (1919–1939) (Forestiera Feltrinelli Sibiu, an Important Company with Italian Participation in the Romanian Forestry Industry (1919–1939))." *Revista Bistriței* 19: 257–262.
- Bokor, Zsuzsa, coord. 2017. *În căutarea țărâmului promis. Italienii din România (In Search of the Promised Land. Italians in Romania)*. Cluj-Napoca: Editura Institutului pentru Studierea Problemelor Minorităților Naționale.
- Nagy, Botond. 2019. "Olasz építési vállalkozók Háromszéken a dualizmus korában (Italian Construction Contractors in Háromszék during the Era of Dualism)." In "Eloszta bőkezűen; és termő fa gyanánt": *Tanulmányok Kövér György születésnapjára ("Distributed Generously; and like a Fruitful Tree": Studies for the Birthday of György Kövér)*, edited by Gábor Koloh, Viktor Papp, and Áron Tötös, 256–280. Nagyvárad: Romániai Magyar Doktorandusok és Fiatal Kutatók Szövetsége.
- Scagno, Roberto, ed. 2008. *Veneti in Romania (Venetians in Romania)*. Ravenna: Longo.
- Tomasella, Paolo. 2016. *Emigranti dal Veneto e dal Friuli nella vita economica e culturale della Romania (1848–1948) (Migrants from Veneto and Friuli in the Economic and Cultural Life of Romania (1848–1948))*. Bucurest: Ozalis.

Keywords: Labour migration, Forestry industry, Geospatial networks, Italian migration, Transylvania.